JOHANN SEBASTIAN

BACH

(1685-1750)

BRANDENBURG CONCERTO No. 1

in F

Critical Edition based on the Composer's Manuscript
Edited by Heinrich Besseler

BWV 1046

CONDUCTOR'S SCORE

PREFACE

The six Brandenburg Concertos belong to the world's musical heritage. They were written during the happy years of Bach's appointment as *Kapellmeister* of Prince Leopold of Anhalt-Köthen in the small town of Köthen (1717-1723). The Concertos were commissioned by the Margrave Christian Ludwig of Brandenburg (1677-1734), youngest son of the Grand Elector. Originally scholars had been inclined to believe that Bach had met the Margrave in Carlsbad or Meiningen. However, we know today that the prince resided in Berlin where Bach paid him a visit, probably in 1718. At that time in Berlin a new harpsichord was being built for the Court of Köthen, which the *Kapellmeister* collected himself; it was the instrument for the solo part of Brandenburg Concerto No. 5. The majority of the excellent *"Kapellmusiker"* in the Köthen orchestra also hailed from Berlin. There Bach dispatched the dedicatory full score in his own hand, the preface of which was signed on March 21, 1721.

We know today that at the time of the Margrave's death his band comprised but six musicians although it disposed of twenty desks. But the dedicatory score in Berlin shows no traces of having been used. Today we know the reason for that too, for the scoring of the Brandenburg Concertos tallies exactly with Bach's orchestra at Köthen. Except for the heavily scored Concerto No. 1 which was presumably written for a special occasion, the scoring is everywhere adjusted to the orchestral conditions of Köthen. Concerto No. 2 gives the solo trumpeter Johann Ludwig Schreiber opportunities to show his mettle; Concerto No. 4 offers similar scope to the leader of the orchestra, Joseph Spieß, who presumably had to play also the other violin solos. Bach himself (according to a statement by his son Carl Philipp Emanuel) preferred to play the viola. As no other player for that instrument can be traced, it is a fair guess that he may have usually directed the whole orchestra from the viola-desk. That would explain the layout of Concerto No. 6 in which Prince Leopold – who was a gamba player – could participate in a solo part of moderate difficulty. There is little doubt that Bach himself played the harpsichord in Concerto No. 5, thus forsaking the viola part. As that instrument was indispensable for the construction of the whole work, it had to be taken over by the second violin because of the small number of players available. Hence, the fact that a part for a second violin is missing in Concerto No. 5 also results from the peculiar conditions at the Court of Köthen.

When Bach copied out the dedicatory full score in 1721, he probably selected these six Concertos from other already existing works. The French title page refers to them as *Concerts avec plusieurs instruments.* That indicates that the pieces are not conceived as soloistic concertos, but as concerti grossi, according to the Italian term. Each concerto is scored differently. The composer is obviously at pains to demonstrate the variability of layout in the case of such music. Even from a stylistic point of view the pieces differ from one another so much, that they must have been composed over a considerable span of time.

Concerts avec plusieurs instruments evidently demand at least two soloists. In chamber music, Italy favored a trio setting with two melody parts of equal range and a bass; it was this model which became Bach's point of departure. His famous Double Concerto for two violins may have been composed in the early Köthen days around 1718; but it did not become part of this collection. However, Concerto No. 6 for two violas and two gamba parts, the style of which points to the same period, was included in it after all. Is it possible that Bach played this concerto to the Margrave on the occasion of his visit to Berlin in 1718? His instrument in that case was certainly the viola.

There is no doubt that **Concerto No. 6 in B-flat** was written for Köthen. Evidently Bach acceded here gracefully to Prince Leopold's desire to play in community with his Kapellmeister. Surely, the six strings were played solo, and the work was not conceived as a concerto in the modern sense of the term but as a kind of communal *"Spielmusik."* All movements are musically determined by the dialog of the two violas who exchange their principal subjects in the manner of an Italian trio sonata, forming even a veritable *stretto* at the beginning. In the *Adagio ma non tanto* their discourse grows into a beautiful and vivid duet, this time however without the support of the gambas. That the music is nevertheless conceived as a concerto is borne out by the frequently recurring *ritornello* in the first and third movements which is invariably scored as a tutti of six parts. It throws into relief the soloistic parts, mostly determined by the duet of the violas: vigorously and energetically in the first movement, in the final *Allegro* however, progressing with the swinging buoyancy of a jig. The concerto proves how Bach (around 1718) achieved a synthesis of his two main models of Italian instrumental music: trio sonata and concerto. By adjusting them to the peculi-

arities of his favorite instrument he created the intensely personal sonorities of this concerto for violas and gambas.

The next step is marked by **Concerto No. 3 in G** which today is more often than not performed by a string orchestra. Under Bach's direction the parts were played by soloists; maybe the three violins received support from *ripieno* players. The general character of the work is that of a communal *Spielmusik*, closely related to Concerto No. 6 for violas and gambas. Up-to-date composers had preferred to compose concertante music of this sort in groups of two. Now Bach started to write in groups of three parts of equality. This represented a personal innovation which was in no way popular in Italy. The trio of violas, led by Bach himself from the first desk, now formed the center, flanked by three violins, three violoncelli and bass. That arrangement resulted in a style of typical Bachian polyphony. It resulted also in a masterpiece of part-writing and of motivic development! The first movement is based completely on the initial motif which penetrates everything with its energetic rhythm. *Tuttis* and soloistic episodes are hardly distinguishable; the grandiose continuity of the movement creates the impression of super-human indivisibility. Instead of a middle movement, two Adagio-chords alone establish a caesura and brief repose. The third movement (*Allegro*) represents the final movement in the form of a jig, based on a tempestuous scale-motif which determines the entire movement from the first to the last note with its semiquaver rhythm.

The heavily-scored **Concerto No. 1 in F** seems to have been the composer's favorite, for he utilized it three times later for cantatas written in Leipzig. In the original version of the concerto, the solo part of the *Violino piccolo* is missing. Already in the Hunting-Cantata No. 208 "Was mir behagt, ist nur die muntre Jagd" Bach had employed the combination of two horns and three oboes; the final chorus of that cantata with its jolly fanfares for the horns is closely related to the structure and atmosphere of the concerto's first movement. At least the first movement served in 1716 as introduction to the hunting cantata, which begins with a recitative; this fact can be deduced from the title *Sinfonia*. Bach probably used all three movements in 1716 for the introductory music. Besides the powerful and joyous *Allegro*, there is the *Adagio*, whose depth of feeling grips us with its unique expressive power. The final version of the concerto was composed in the autumn of 1717 when Bach was in Dresden at the time of his projected contest with Marchant. He then re-wrote as a concerto movement the third movement *Allegro* for the *Konzertmeister* Volumier; it is in the rhythm of a jig. The French *Violino piccolo*, sounding a third higher, was given rewarding solo passages and was later incorporated into the other movements. Despite the new *Allegro* third movement, Bach retained the original finale. He even extended it with the result that the original minuet with two trios was eventually transformed into a rondo-like cycle of minuets, the seven sections of which offer the orchestra an impressive opportunity to present their variety of colors.

The original draft of Concerto No. 1 (without soloist) and the Concertos Nos. 3 and 6 (in the character of communal *Spielmusiken*) share certain features of style. They are determined everywhere by the principle of free polyphony. The parts for single instruments enter into free combinations with one another whereby even horns and oboes are made to participate in the general intercourse. In that respect **Concerto No. 2 in F** introduces a novelty. The typographical arrangement of the full score already suggests that trumpet, recorder, oboe and violin are to form a quartet of soloists, contrasting with the *tutti* of the string orchestra. Such conditions afford a lucid structure. As the concerto's thematic matter too is determined by two- and four-bar periods, the whole work achieves a degree of transparency unusual for Bach. It was presumably written around 1719, i.e. during the second half of Bach's stay in Köthen. In the case of this "Solo-Group Concerto" the four solo instruments utilize identical themes despite their contrasting characters. The attractiveness of the first movement lies in the fact that the motif of the soloists becomes audible in ever changing colors and orchestral combinations until the buoyant motif of the *tutti* asserts itself. In contradistinction to the full sonority of that movement, the second movement, limited to flute, oboe, violin and continuo, presents an *Andante* based on sigh-motifs of a distinctly *empfindsam* character. When the string orchestra is occasionally added in the third movement, it only accompanies the group of solo-players. That group progresses fugally and on the basis of a humorous trumpet-motif. It is with virtuosity that the trumpet part fits itself into the chamber music ensemble with the recorder. Thus, Bach concludes the concerto – as he was to do frequently later on – with a fugue which is transformed into a character piece.

Concerto No. 4 in G was presumably composed at the same time. The four-part string orchestra is opposed to a solo group of a violin and two recorders, frequently supported by continuo. It is again the case of a "Solo-Group Concerto" as in No. 2; this time, however, with clearly differentiated solo parts. The recorders form a

duo of winds which differs strongly from the virtuoso part of the violin. In the third movement there are soloistic stretches reminiscent of a violin concerto, which all but disrupt the cohesion of the solo group. The concerto may have originated from the atmosphere of Bach's virtuoso compositions for violin solo around 1719-20. The 3/8 *Allegro* of the first movement derives its character from the recorders, limpidly floating in an atmosphere bereft of mundane gravity. The well-constructed movement is unique with its length of 427 bars; the victory of a sovereign master over the orchestra and all its problems! In the second movement *Andante*, *tutti* and soloists are interlinked by virtue of an expressive, almost emotional, dialog in which the first recorder has the lead. The concerto is wound up by a fugue, similarly to Concerto No. 2. However, this time the serenely swinging *Alla breve* theme does not belong to the group of soloists, but to the *Tutti*. The soloists have only interludes to play from which the development of the principal theme emerges, heading for a gradual climax which eventually culminates in a gorgeous symphony of sound.

Style and scoring suggest that **Concerto No. 5 in D** must be the one which composed last. It is a "Solo-Group Concerto" like Nos. 2 and 4 in which the *Tutti* was kept in three parts in Köthen, for reasons already explained. The solo group consists of violin, flute and harpsichord. Bach ventured upon that unusual combination and thereby created the very first concerto for keyboard. The cadenza of 65 bars for harpsichord solo in the first movement nearly bursts through the framework of the group, thus creating the impression of a concerto for keyboard alone. That movement also surprisingly anticipates the "singing Allegro" of the future. The interweaving of soloists and strings results in a sonorous texture of overwhelming beauty in which the transverse flute (which here appears for the first time) corresponds with a new expressive cantabile type of melody. That applies even to the *affetuoso* middle movement in which flute and violin collaborate with the obligatory harpsichord, achieving true chamber-music-like unity. A fugue concludes the concerto as it did in Nos. 2 and 4. Its jolly first subject in the manner of a jig is treated by soloists and orchestra in collaboration; it leads to a free thematic development. A most singular effect is created by a middle section in b minor, the *cantabile* melody of which seems to establish a second contrasting subject. However, it soon reveals its true nature as a masterly transformation of the main subject. Thus, the music returns without rupture into its home-waters and concludes with a vigorous *Tutti*.

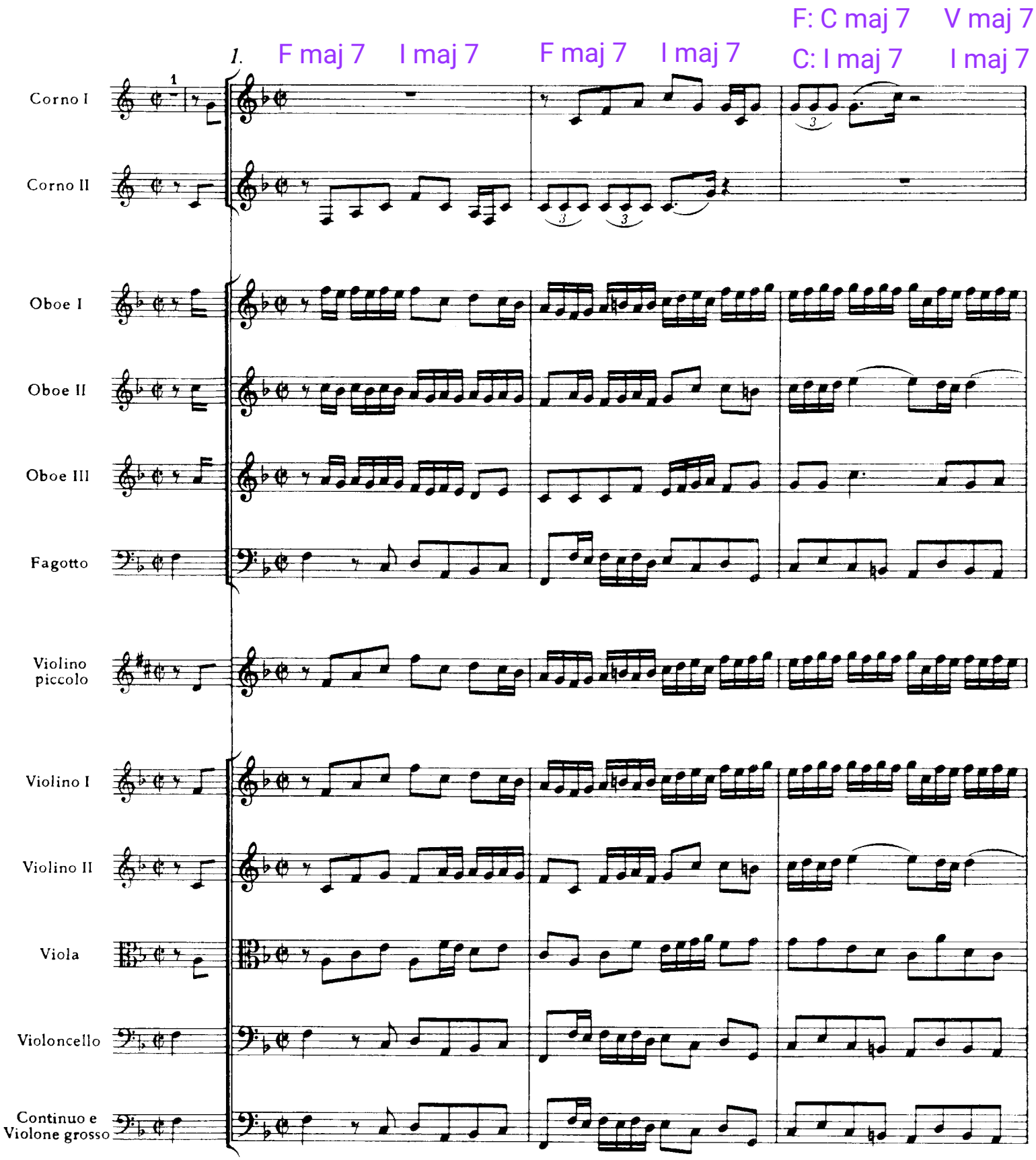
Heinrich Besseler
(translated by H.F. Redlich)

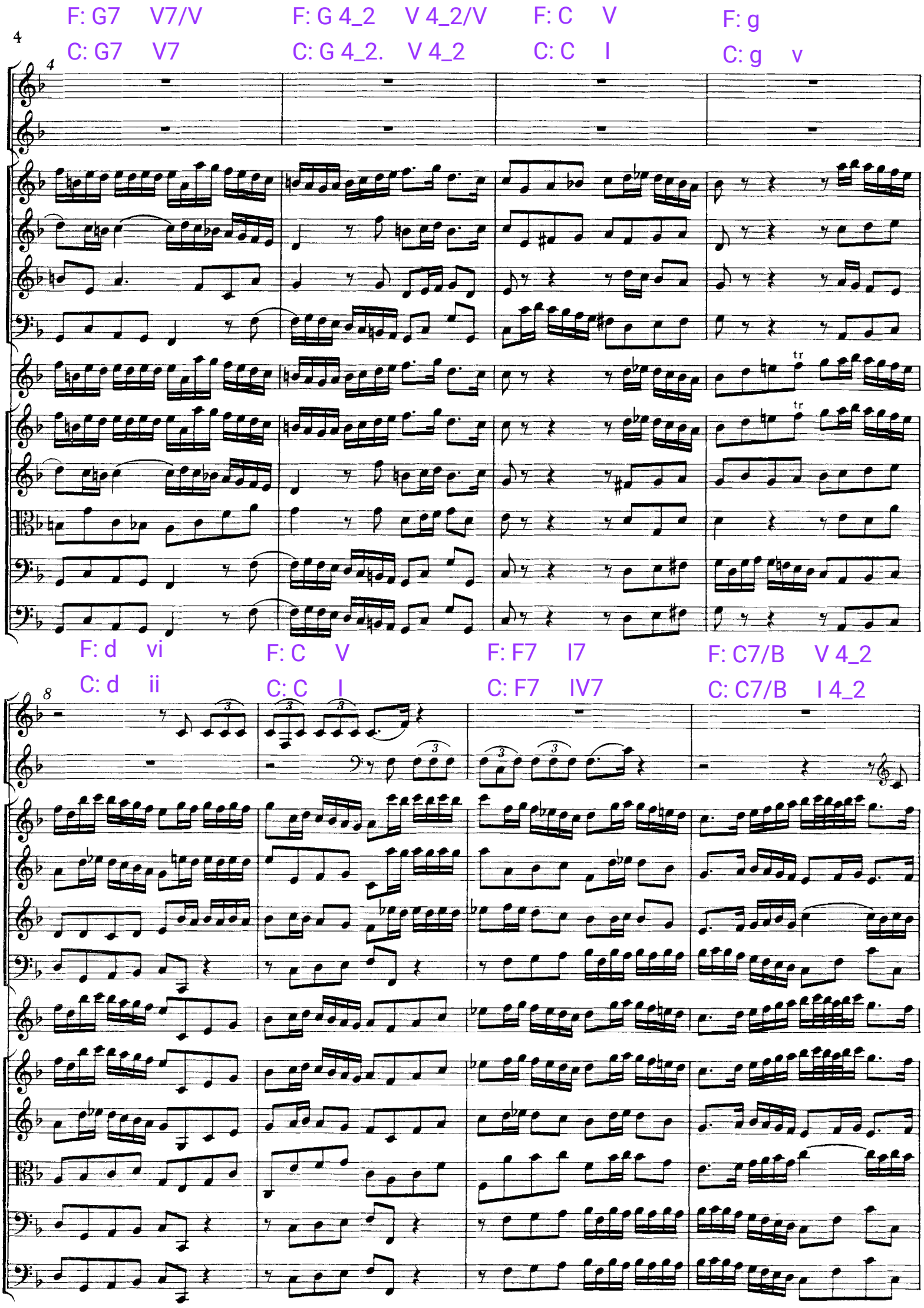
Editorial Note

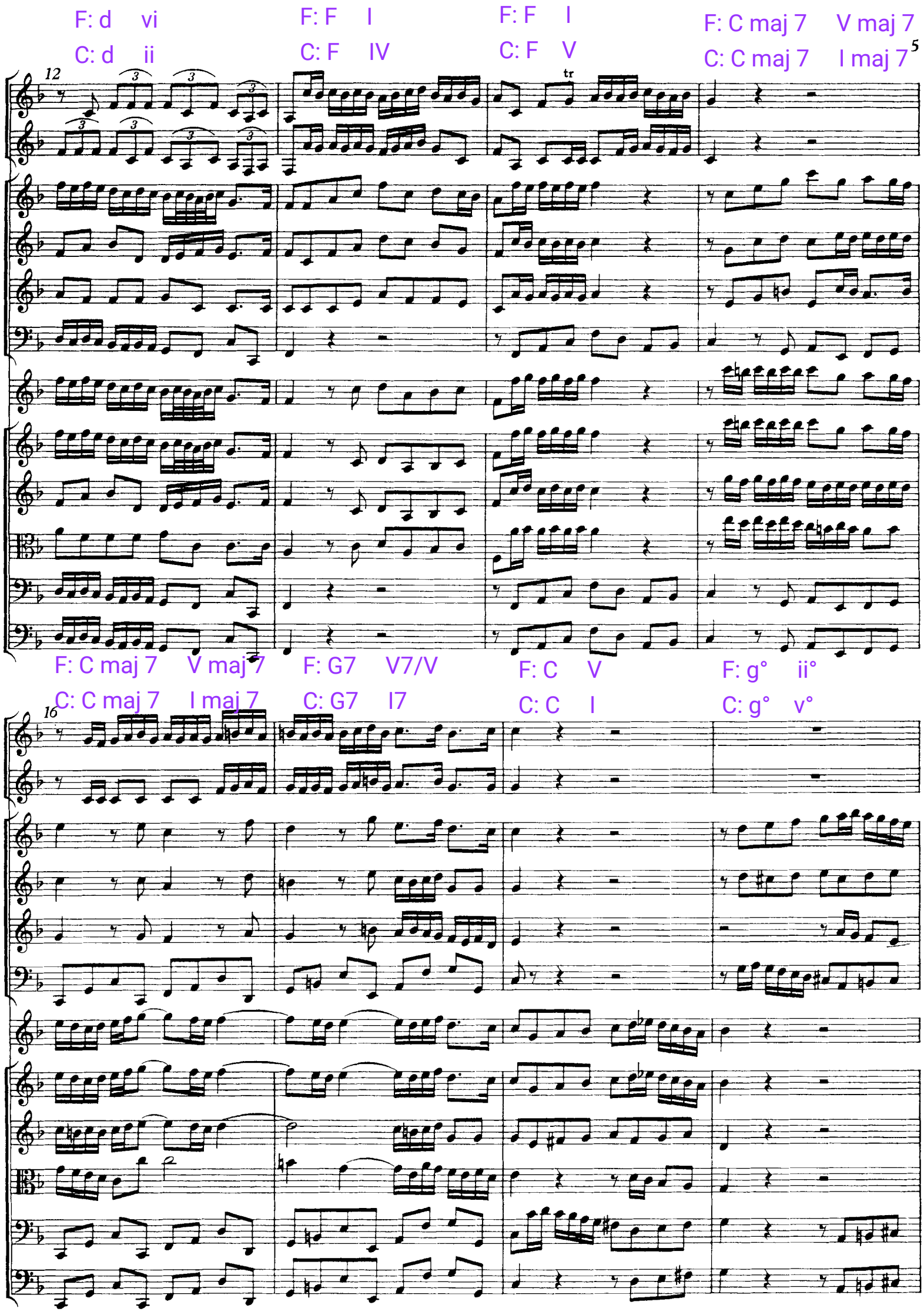
Except for titles of compositions, all editorial additions are clearly marked as such in the score: letters by italics, other signs through smaller or fainter print. Therefore all letters contained in the autograph score, including dynamics such as f, p etc., are here reproduced in normal print. Accidentals are introduced according to the rules of modern musical notation. Additional accidentals, supplied by the editor at his own discretion (i.e. other than such accidentals which become necessary through adherence to the rules of modern musical notation) are printed above the note; only in the continuo parts are they put into brackets and printed before the note, in order to exclude any confusion with the figured bass.

Concerto I

BWV Nr. 1046




4
F: G7 V7/V
C: G7 V7
F: G 4_2 V 4_2/V
C: G 4_2. V 4_2
F: C V
C: C I
F: g
C: g v
F: d vi
C: d ii
F: C V
C: C I
F: F7 I7
C: F7 IV7
F: C7/B V 4_2
C: C7/B I 4_2
8


F: d vi
C: d ii
F: F I
C: F IV
F: F I
C: F V
F: C maj 7 V maj 7
C: C maj 7 I maj 7
5
12
tr
F: C maj 7 V maj 7
C: C maj 7 I maj 7
F: G7 V7/V
C: G7 I7
F: C V
C: C I
F: g° ii°
C: g° v°
16

F: d vi | F: d vi | F: F7 I7 | Toni. Bb | F: F7 I7
d: d i | d: d i | d: F7 III7 = Bb: V | Bb: F7 V7

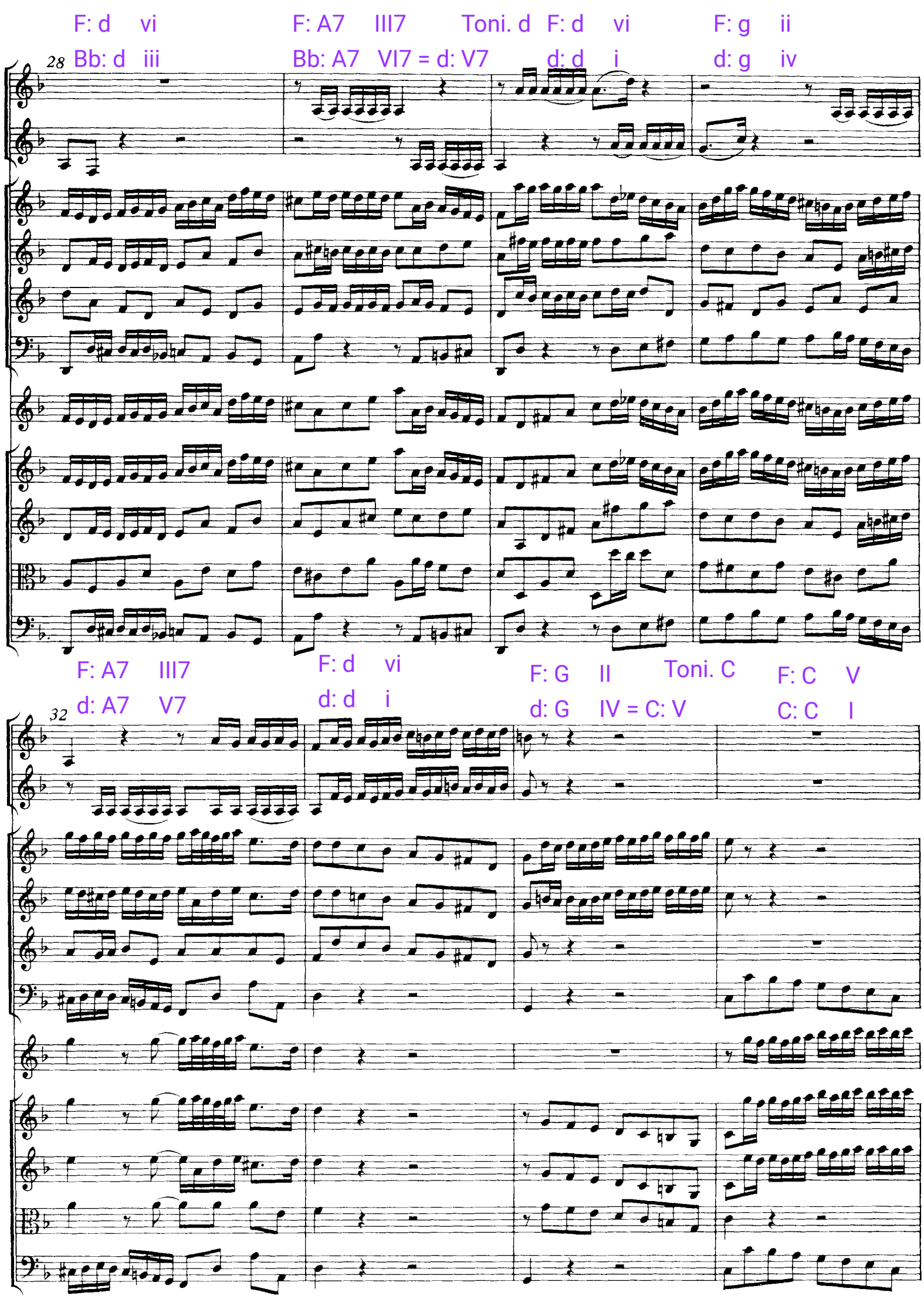
20

tr

Continuo e Violoncello e Violone

F: Bb IV | F: d vi | F: Bb IV | F: d vi
Bb: Bb I | Bb: d iii | Bb: Bb I | Bb: Bb I

24


28
F: d vi
Bb: d iii
F: A7 III7
Bb: A7 VI7 = d: V7
Toni. d
F: d vi
d: d i
F: g ii
d: g iv
32
F: A7 III7
d: A7 V7
F: d vi
d: d i
F: G II
d: G IV = C: V
Toni. C
F: C V
C: C I

36

F: F7 I7
C: F7 IV7

F: dsus4 visus4
C: dsus4 iisus4

F: F maj 7 I maj 7
C: F maj 7 IV maj 7

F: G9 II9
C: G9 V9

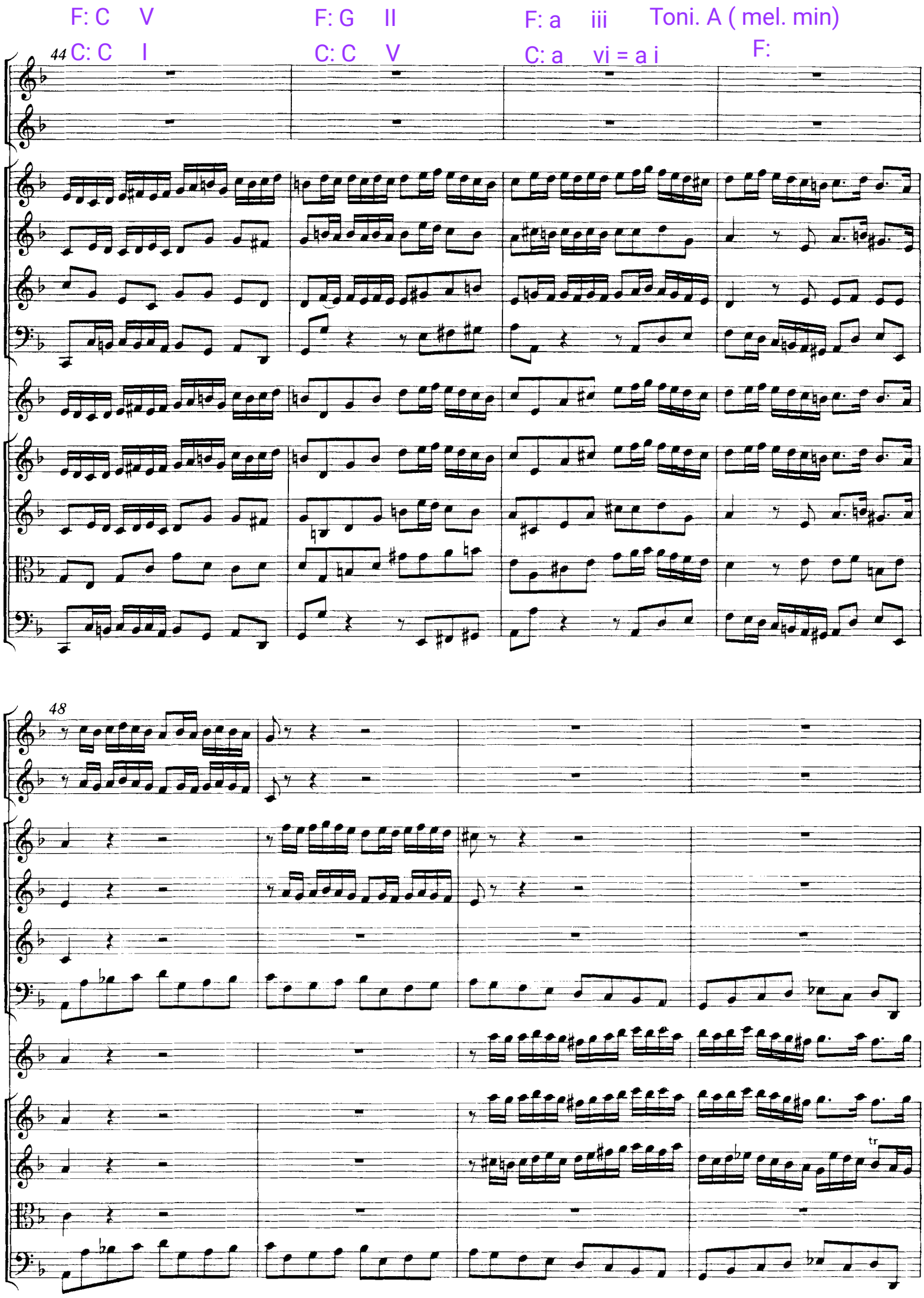
F: A min 9 iii9
C: A min 9 vi9

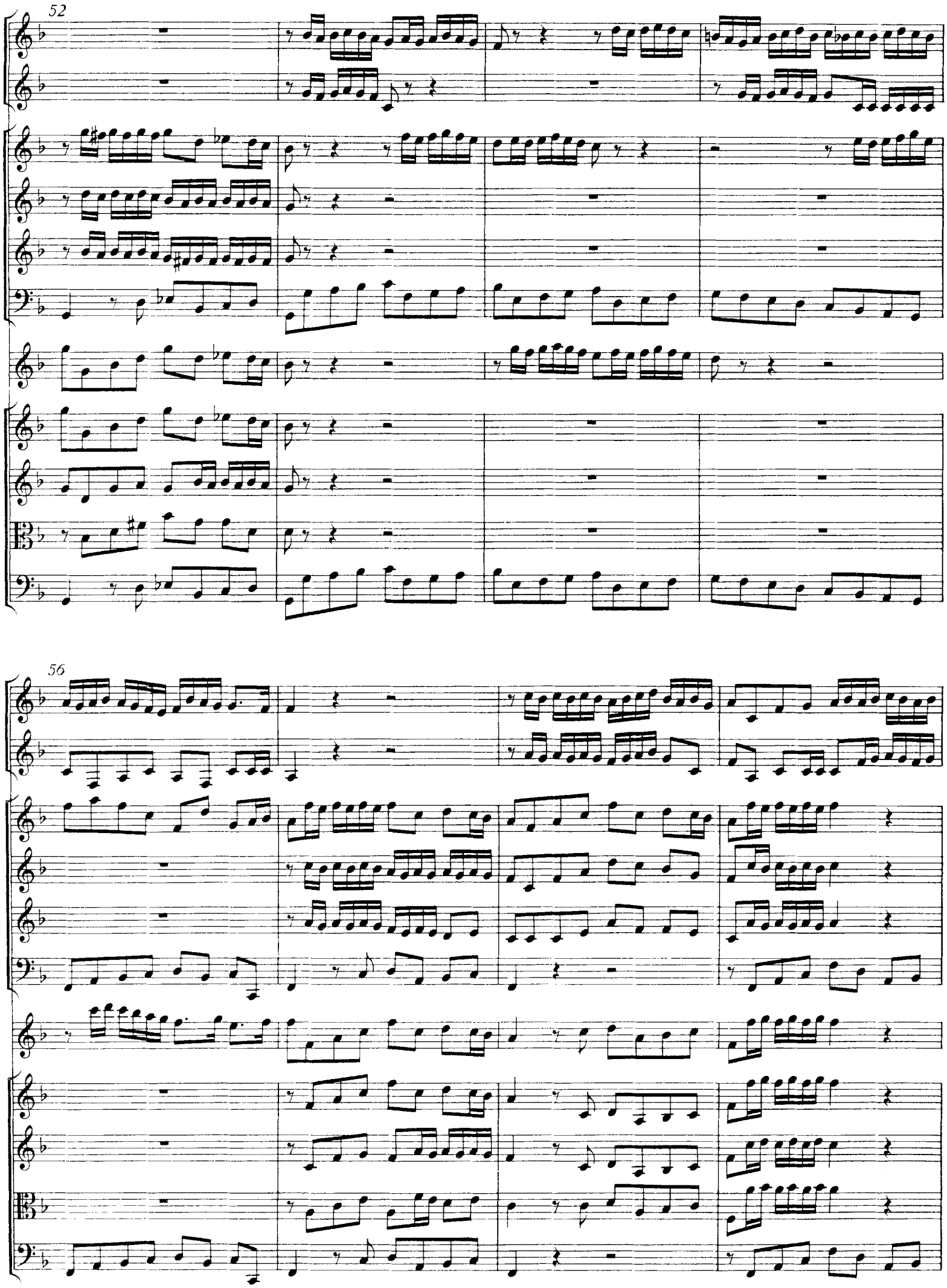
F: f° i°
C: f° iv°

F: G7/F II 4_2
C: G7/F V 4_2

F: C V
C: C I

40


F: C V
C: C I
F: G II
C: C V
F: a iii
C: a vi = a i
Toni. A (mel. min)
F:
44
48
tr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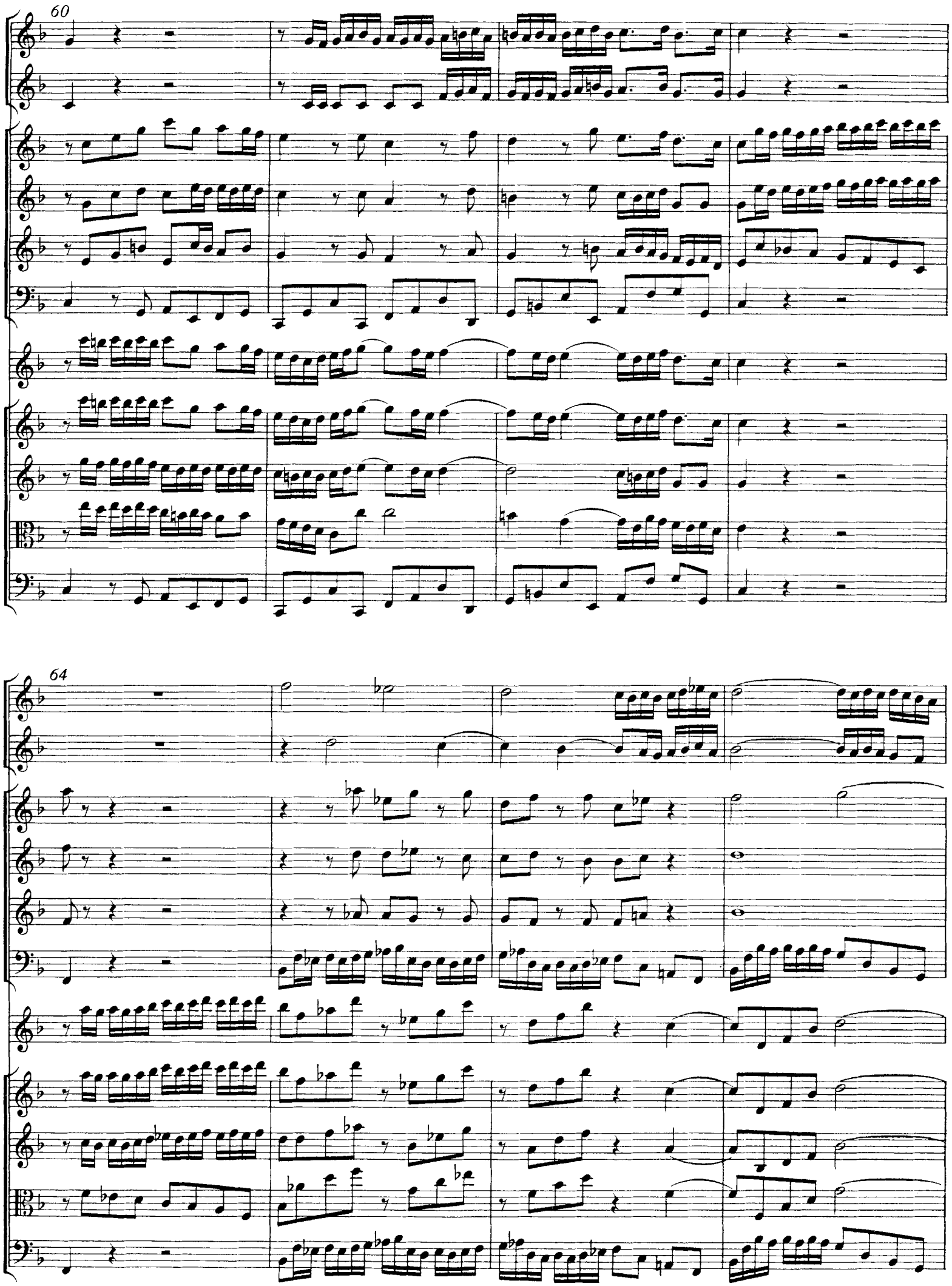
56


60
64

68

F: C maj 7 V maj 7

F maj 7 I maj 7 F maj 7 I maj 7 C: I maj 7 I maj 7

72

76

Violoncello

Continuo e Violone

80

Continuo e Violoncello e Violone

2. Adagio

Oboe I

Oboe II

Oboe III

Fagotto

Violino piccolo

Violino I

Violino II

Viola

Continuo e Violoncello e Violone grosso

sempre piano

piano

piano sempre

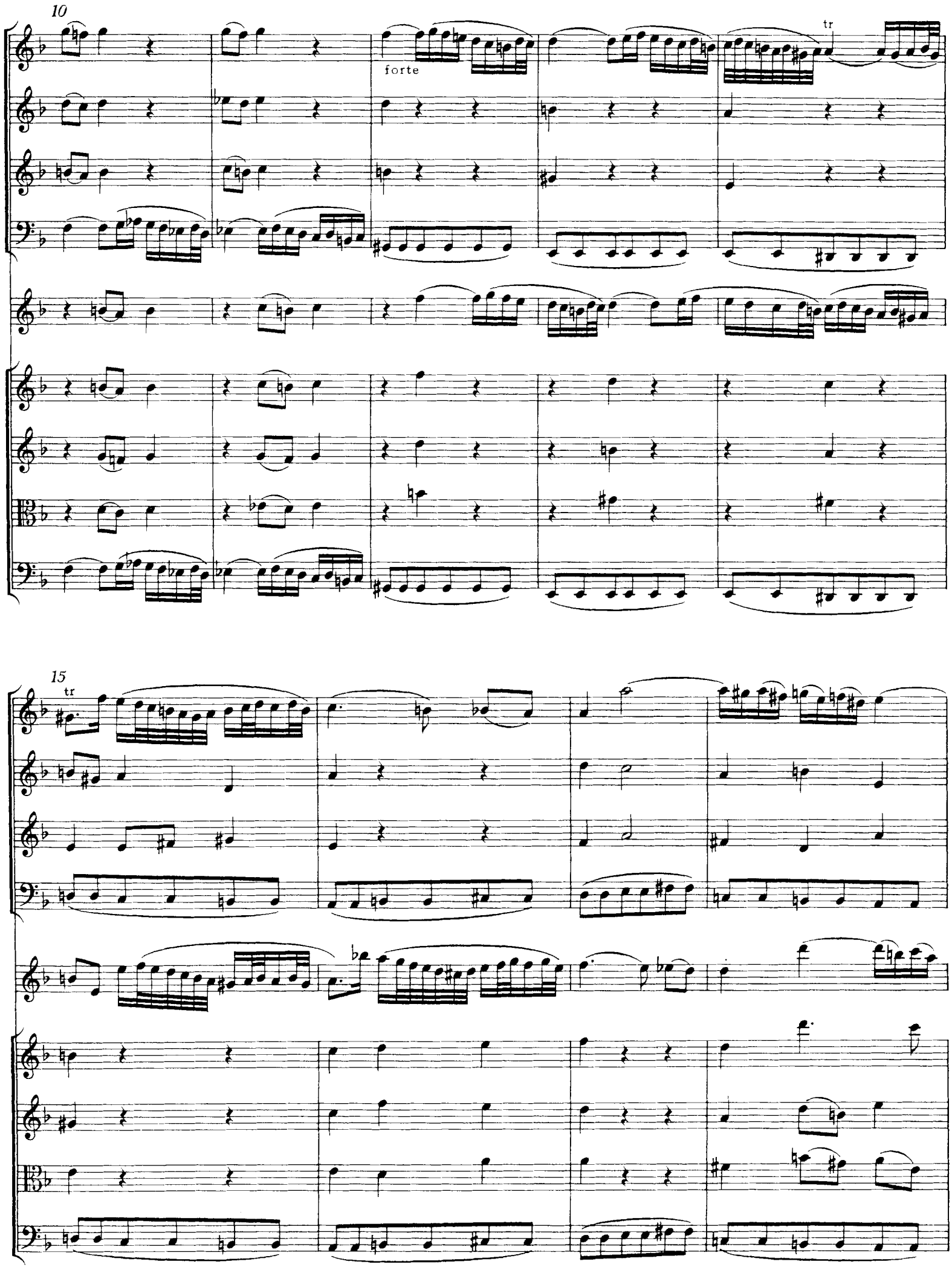
piano sempre

tr

5 piano

forte

piano


10
forte
tr
15
tr

19

piano

forte

tr

piano

tr

24

tr

28

tr

piano

tr

piano

tr

33

piano

tr

f

p

f

f

piano

f

tr

f

p

f

f

p

f

f

p

f

f

p

f

3. Allegro

Corno I
Corno II
Oboe I
Oboe II
Oboe III
Fagotto
Violino piccolo
Violino I
Violino II
Viola
Continuo
e Violoncello
e Violone grosso

tr

5

10

tr

15

tr

piano sempre

20

piano sempre

piano sempre

piano sempre

piano sempre

pianissimo sempre

tr

pianissimo sempre

pianissimo sempre

pianissimo sempre

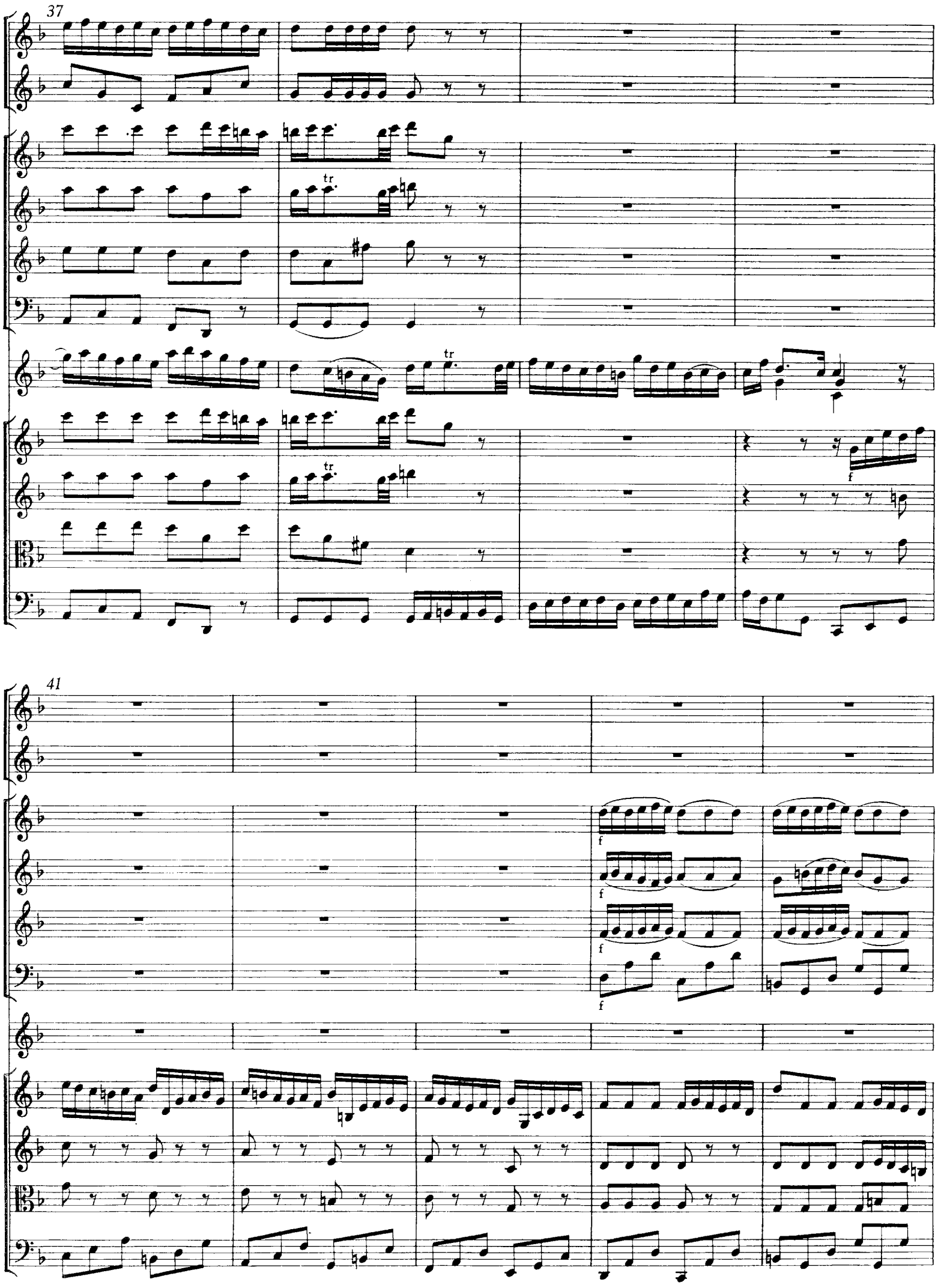
tr

25

29

33

tr


37
tr
tr
tr
f
41
f
f
f
f

46

51

p

p

p

tr

tr

piano

p

p

piano

55

tr

tr

tr

tr

60

f

f

f

f

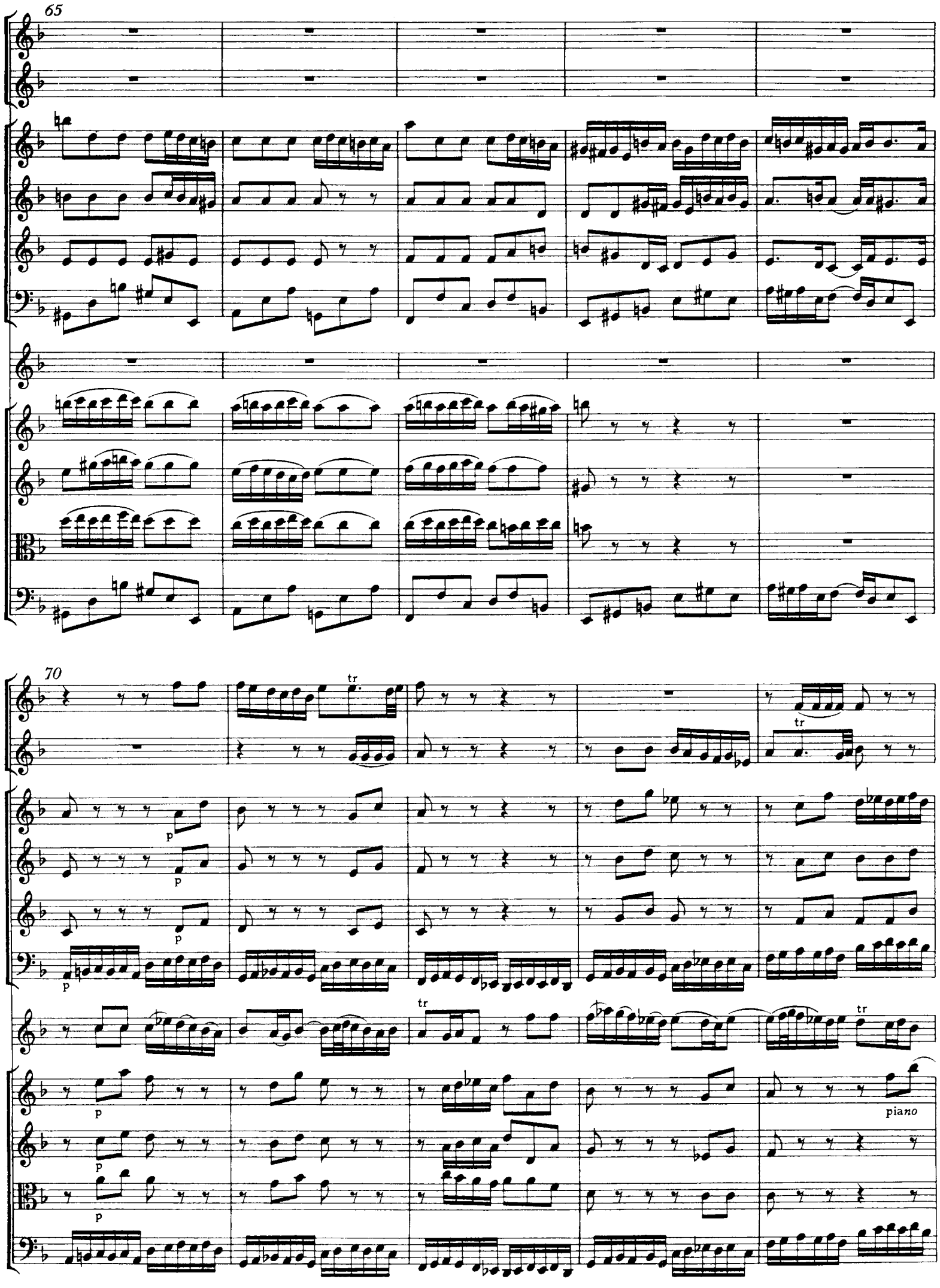
tr

f

f

f

f


65
70
tr
p
piano

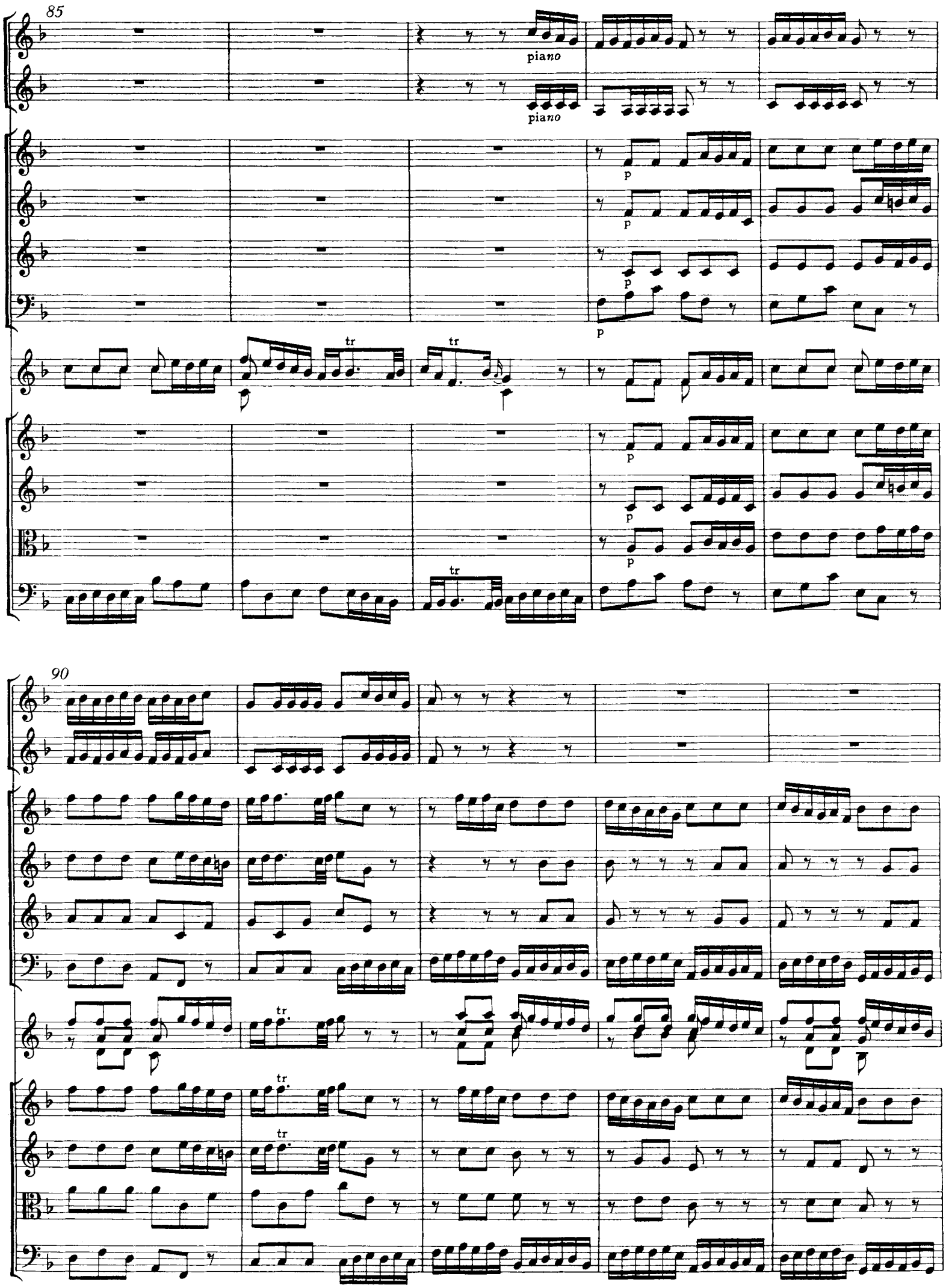
75

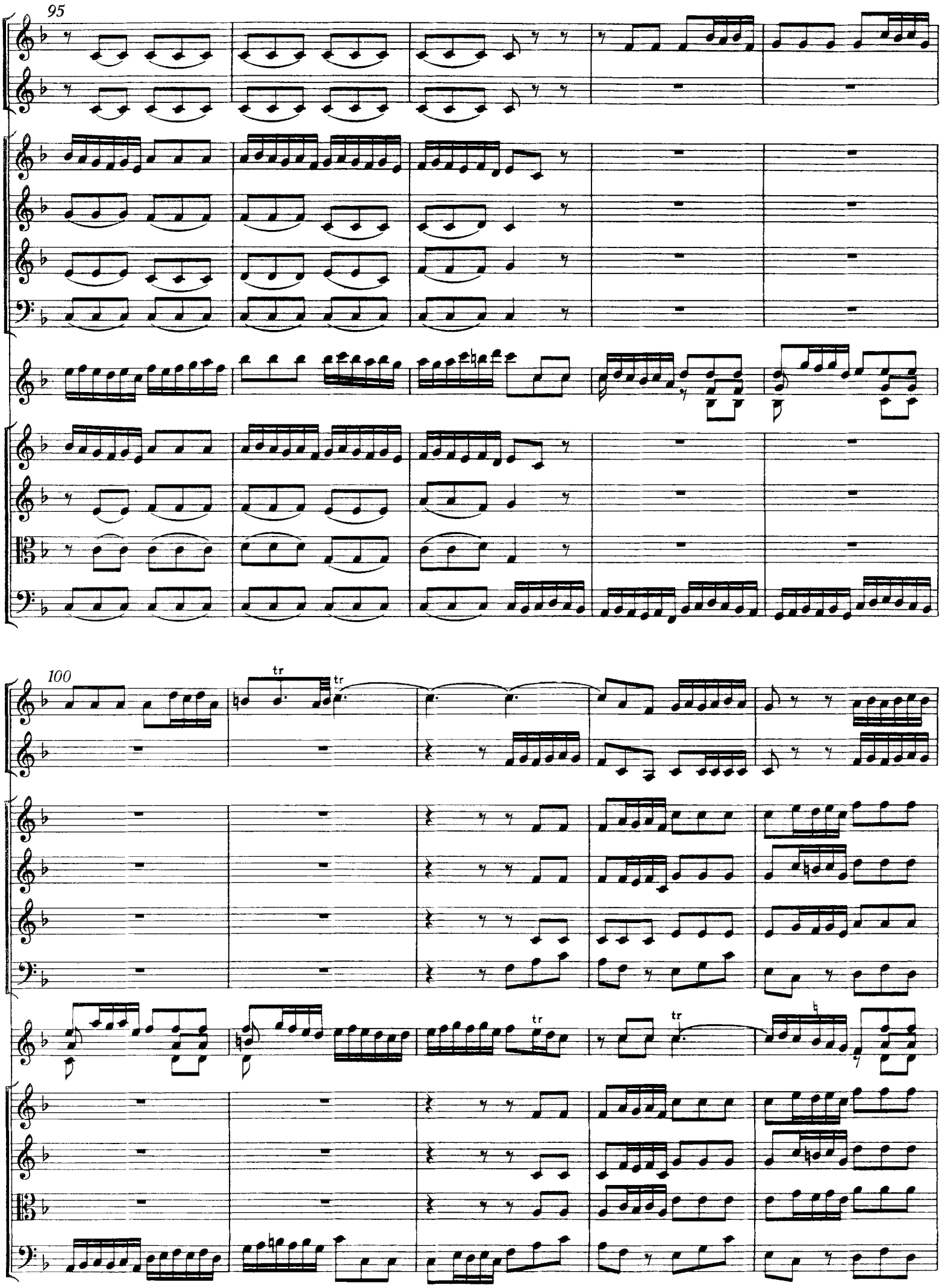
80

Adagio

Allegro

Adagio


85
piano
piano
p
p
p
p
tr
tr
p
p
p
tr
90
tr
tr


95
100
tr
tr
tr
tr

105

tr

tr

tr

110

tr

tr

tr

tr

tr

tr

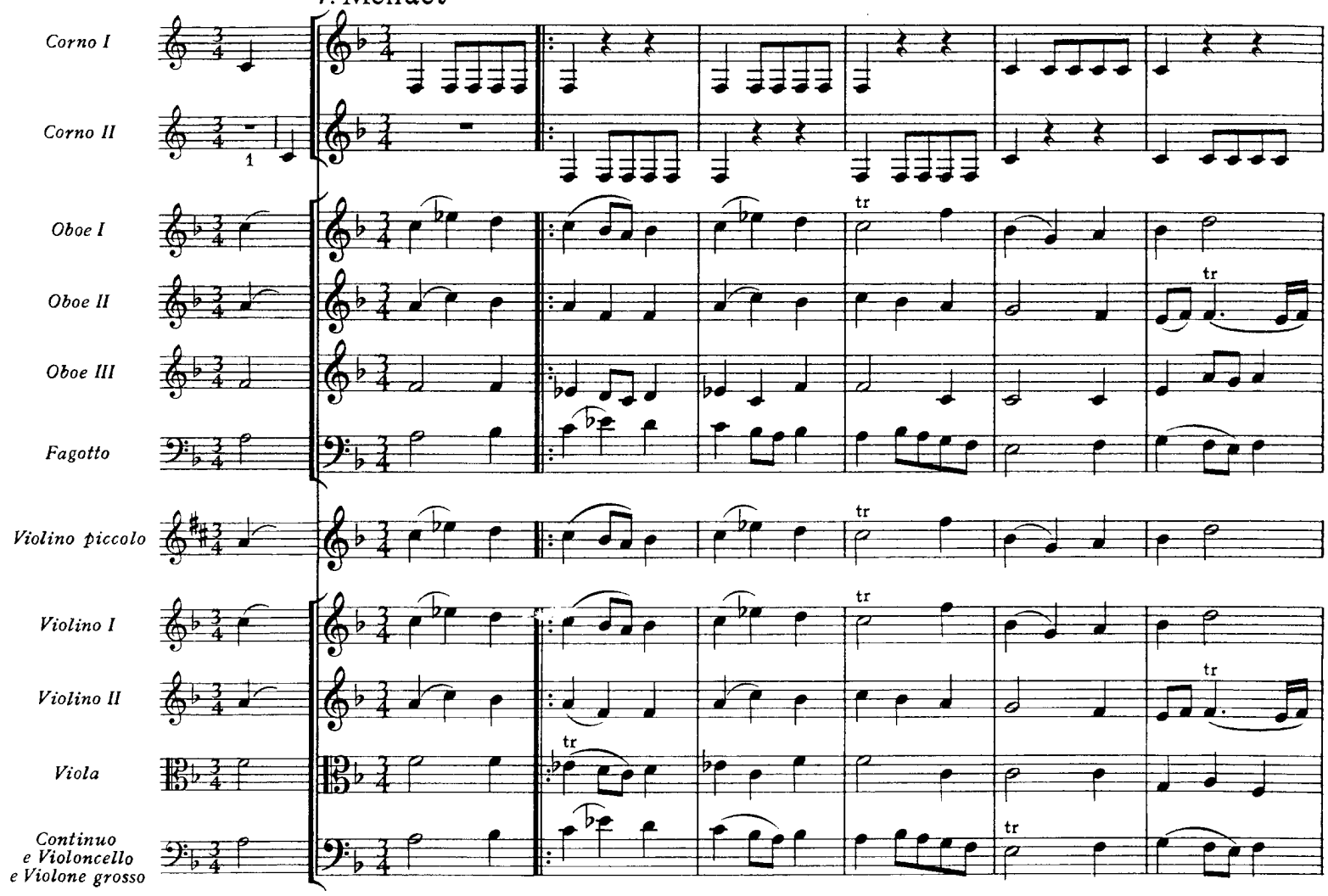
115

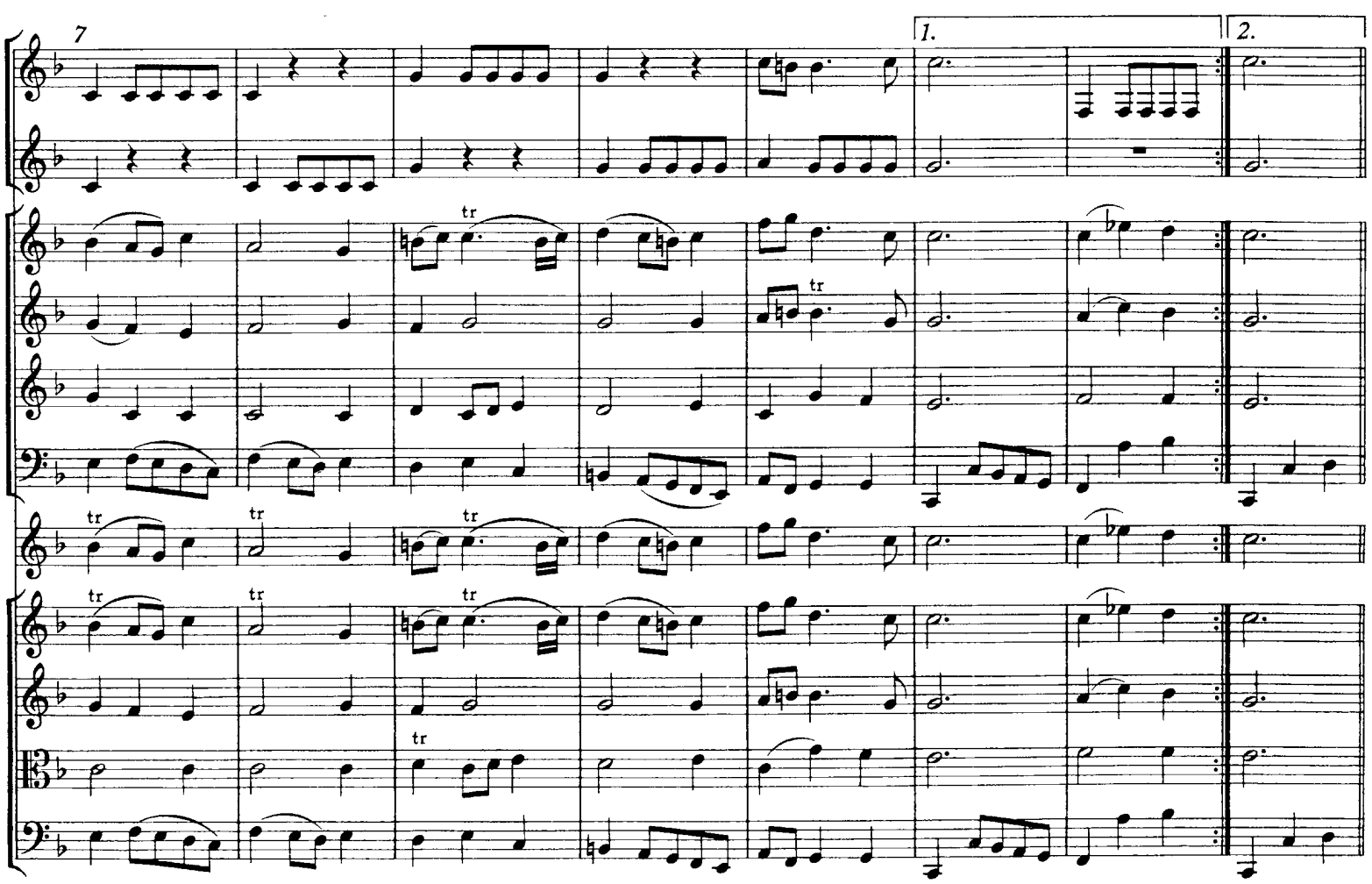
120

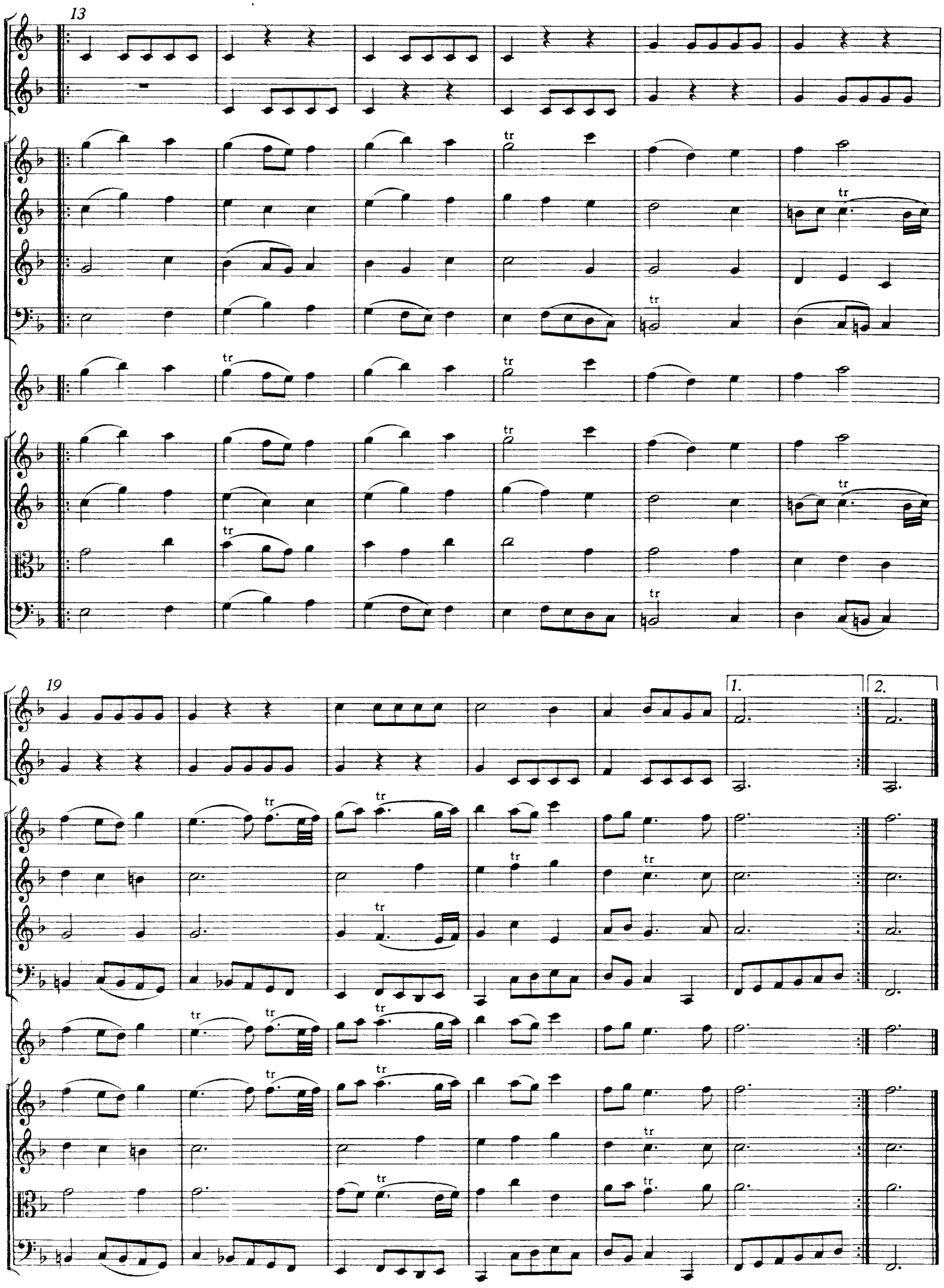
tr

4. Menuet

Corno I
Corno II
Oboe I
Oboe II
Oboe III
Fagotto
Violino piccolo
Violino I
Violino II
Viola
Continuo e Violoncello e Violone grosso






13
tr
19
1.
2.

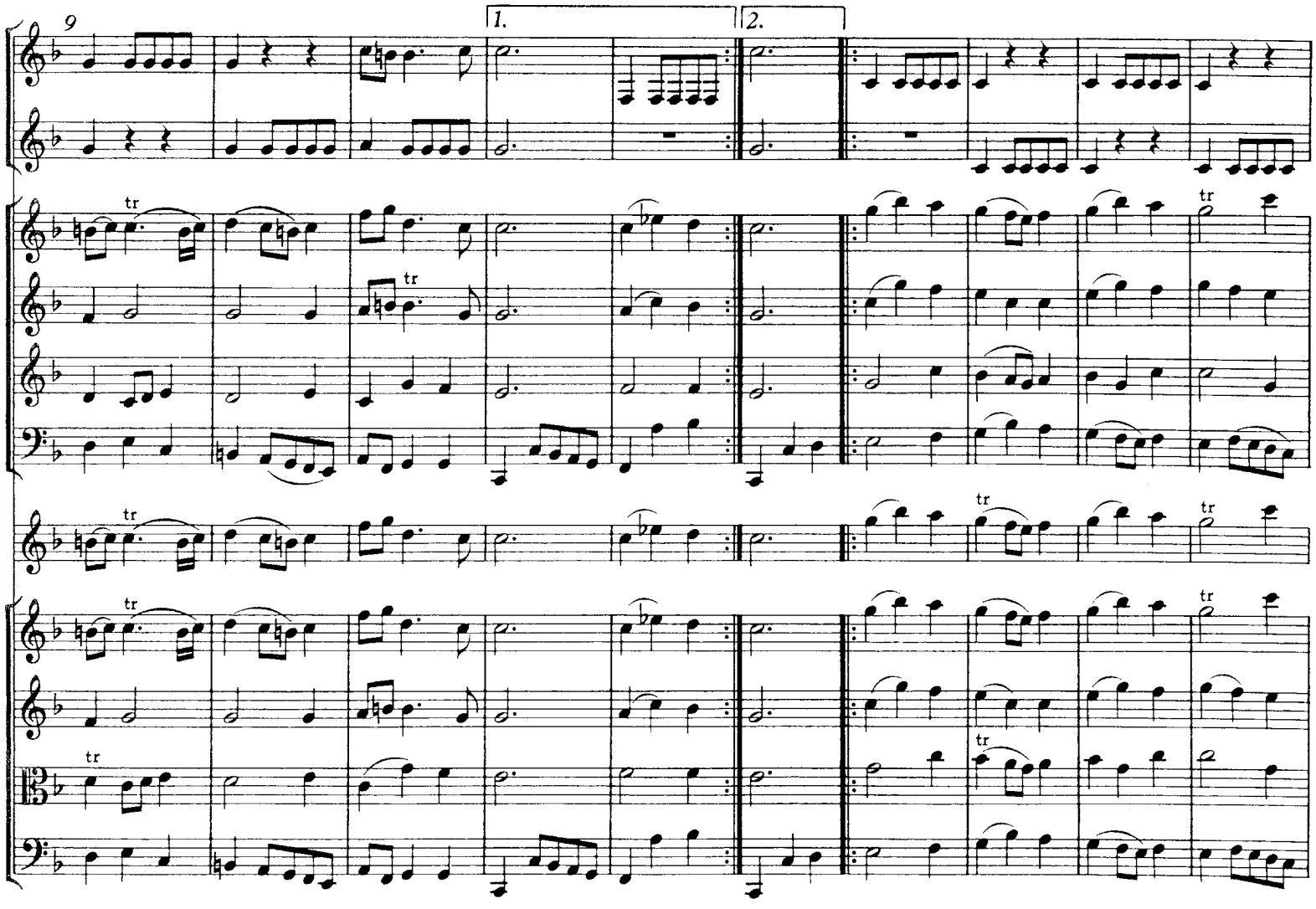
Trio

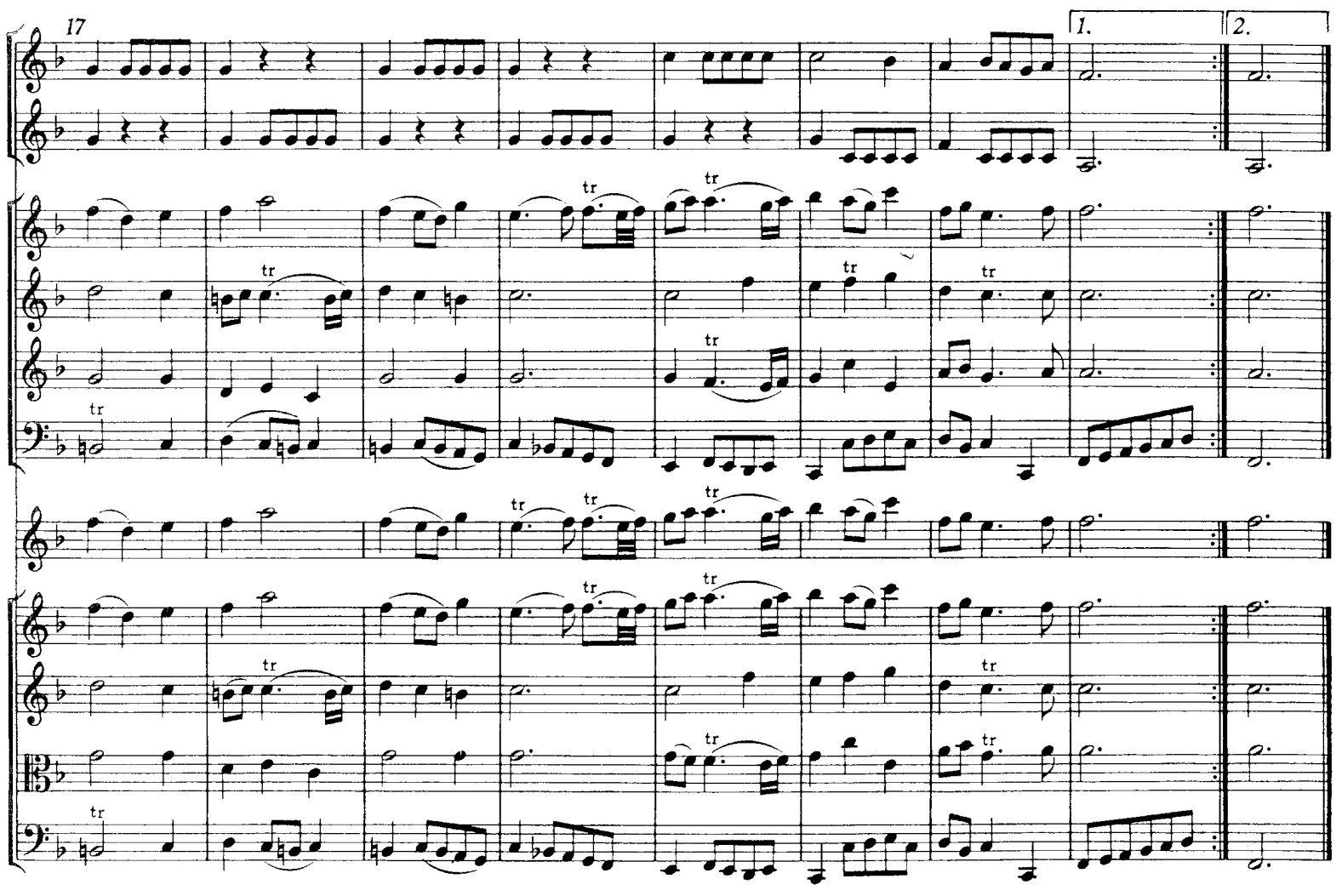
Oboe I
Oboe II
Fagotto

Menuet [1]

Corno I
Corno II
Oboe I
Oboe II
Oboe III
Fagotto
Violino piccolo
Violino I
Violino II
Viola
Continuo
e Violoncello
e Violone grosso

1) Die Wiederkehr des Menuetts wird hier sowie auf Seite 36 und Seite 39 durch Repetitionsvermerke gefordert. Ihren Wortlaut bringt der Kritische Bericht. Die Wiederholungen innerhalb des Menuetts sind nicht obligatorisch.


9
1.
2.
tr


17
1.
2.
tr

Polonaise

Violino I
tutti, ma piano

Violino II
tutti, ma piano

Viola
tutti, ma piano

Continuo
e Violoncello
e Violone grosso

Violino piccolo tacet

piano

piano

8

1.

2.

17

forte

forte

26

piano

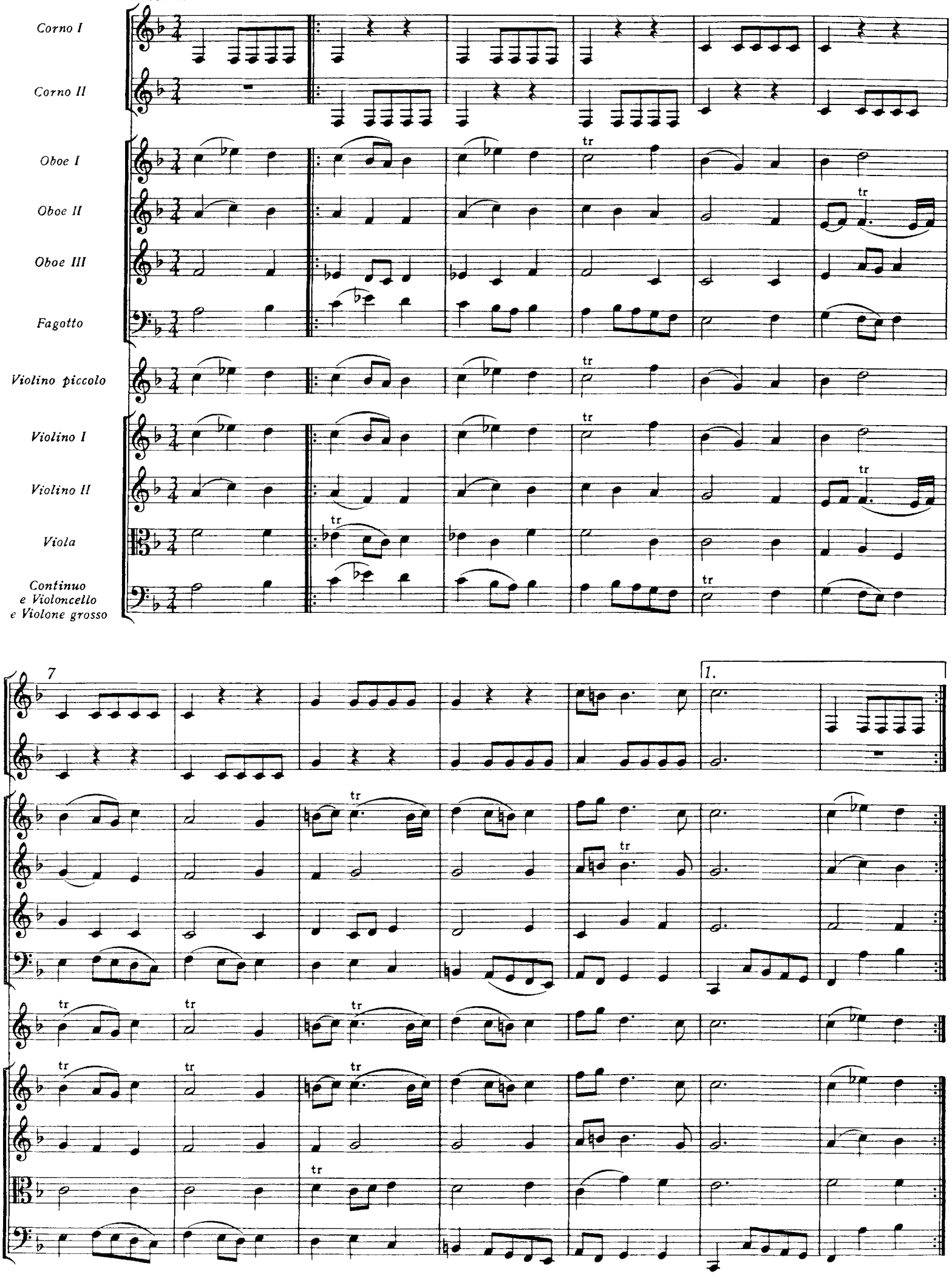
piano

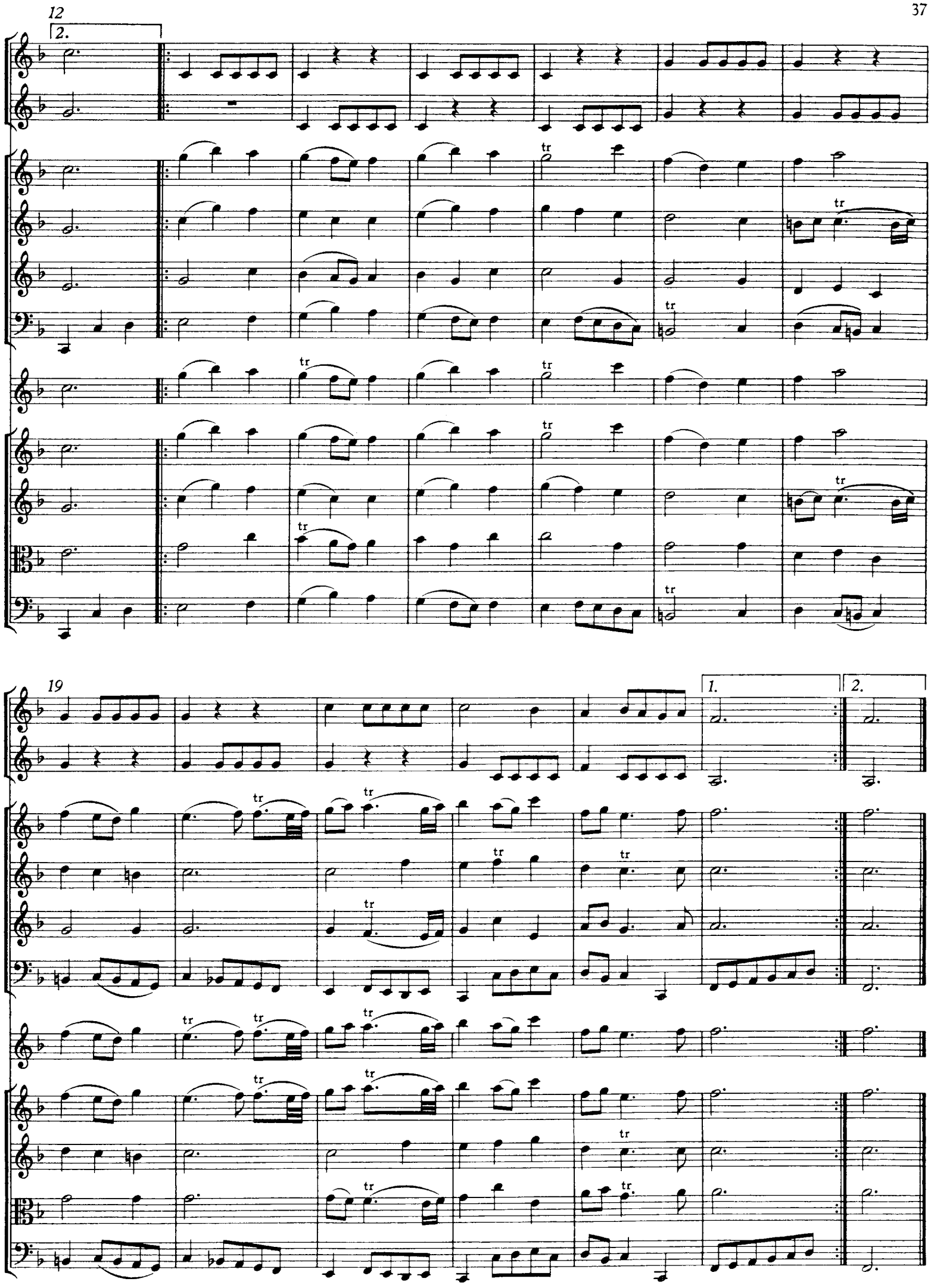
piano

1.

2.

Menuet


Corno I
Corno II
Oboe I
Oboe II
Oboe III
Fagotto
Violino piccolo
Violino I
Violino II
Viola
Continuo
e Violoncello
e Violone grosso
7
1.
tr


12
2.
tr
19
1.
2.

Trio

Corno I

Corno II

Tutti gli Oboi in unisono

7

13

20

26

tr

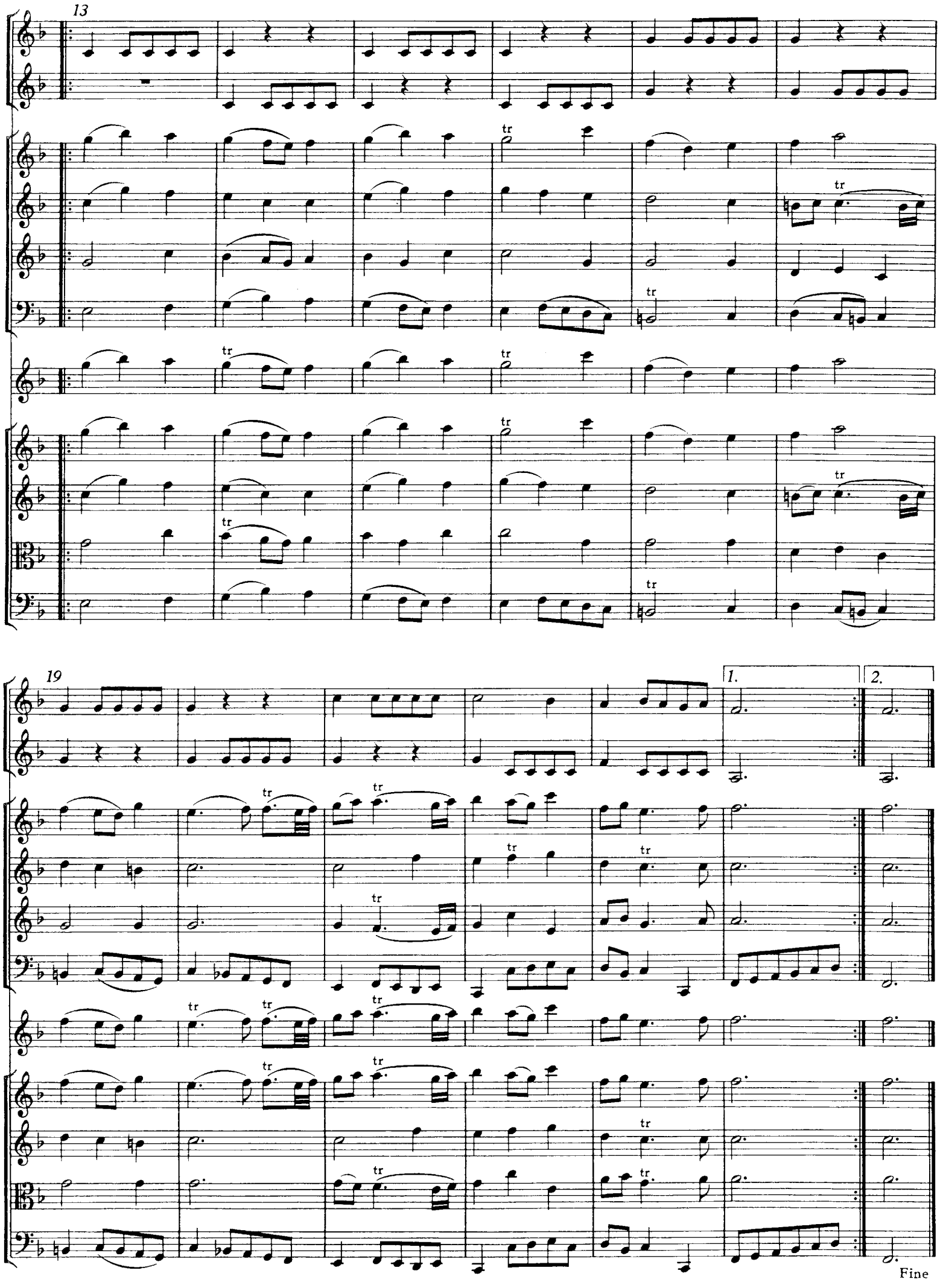
Menuet

Corno I
Corno II
Oboe I
Oboe II
Oboe III
Fagotto
Violino piccolo
Violino I
Violino II
Viola
Continuo
e Violoncello
e Violone grosso

7

1.

2.


13
tr
19
1.
2.
Fine